

[Portion Redacted]

Interviewer 02:06

Right. So when your clients come to you, what is usually the presenting issue or the reason that they seek your services?

Therapist 02:16

But I don't say that it's a it's a or as I'm sorry, outside. So say the typical question of, let's say 50% of the of the of the questions is usually couples. I also know usually couples 50% have the question that one of them wants to live non-monogamous and the other one knows or not as fast or not as involved as as your as our friends. With but falling in love not or vice versa as a typically one wants more and the other want less. Or another that's 50% and the rest is a mixed bag of usually non-monogamous that that are happily leveling non-monogamous or engaging in conflicts or difficulties or so I, I also go it's either singles or, let's say, separate individuals. Let's put it that way. And those are either single or involved with with more than one relationship. Once in a while, I also coach triangles so three people. So I coach the quad, so forth.

Interviewer 03:52

Interesting. I'd love to know more about how you keep that clinical dynamic. If it was a triangle or a quad. But before I ask that, do you do a formal assessment when your clients come in?

Therapist 04:07

Not really. Of course, I have an intake session, but I have no formal nor formal intake. I look at it once in a while. So there is an EFT related questionnaire and there is also an ACT related questionnaire. But these are all they are giving me parts of the answer. So I look for specimens that give me gives me the broad, broad view that I would need. Sometimes I consider it, but it's not there and I should make it. And as another researcher, I have no, no, possibility to validate.

Interviewer 04:54

So what is in this ETF related questionnaire? If you remain.

Therapist 05:00

It, it checks on. I actually I don't know if it's validated, but it's. What are the English names? It tests the 200 countries, I always have an English. I'm not sure if these are the right right English and an English version with accessibility, responsivity and engagement.

Interviewer 05:36

All right. Engagement. And for ACT.

Therapist 05:38

That's the test. I don't think that it is a validated assessment. It test is your psychological flexibility.

Interviewer 05:51

All right.

Therapist 01:29

So I also could say that the EFT that's the connection and the ACT assessment is test the individual autonomy, which which is important.

Interviewer 06:06

Interesting. All right. And these EFT and ACT related questionnaires, do you give them every time?

Therapist 06:14

No, no, no. Frankly, hardly. As they give only a few answers. And it would not even be complete.

Interviewer 06:28

If that because of the questionnaire itself or because of the couples not wanting to answer. Why do you find it limited?

Therapist 06:39

Because the question don't give me the answers I need or only very partial. So instead, If my qualitative intake questionnaire.

Interviewer 06:56

And did you pay for these questionnaires?

Therapist 06:58

No, They are both free questionnaires.

Interviewer 07:01

All right. And I think I've touched on this on my email to you as well. But across the years, different relationship therapies and different researchers have characterized the construct of relationship quality quite differently from each other. But I wanted to get your view about it for you. What is the relationship quality?

Therapist 07:24

For me, a good relationship is as a....Let's say, it 's a combination of.. it's what is bonding is not a connection is a stable but flexible. Stable but resilient relationship between autonomous individuals. Stable, resilient and autonomous individuals.

Interviewer 08:09

Interesting. So maybe another angle of maybe asking that question as well is for you. What differentiates couples with higher relationship quality and couples with low relationship quality?

Therapist 08:23

For me, that is very much based on on the individuals you have, you could say psychological flexibility, their their individual autonomy, their individual, how they have learned to deal with their own coping strategies and non-monogamy relationship. All your coping strategies are fired and into a monogamous relationship as well. But non-monogamous even more so the of fully your question but let's say a predictor for a or a good non-monogamous relationship starts with the emotional maturity, the psychological flexibility of the individual.

Interviewer 09:09

When you talk about psychological flexibility, what do you mean exactly?

Therapist 09:15

And that is that is terminology defined in ACT. And so that is that is comprised of of six different pillars, which is you could look at it, look it up as importance to your pillars, acceptance roles that are a six number. You can look it up. It's defined in act.

Interviewer 09:38

No problem. All right. So in your professional experience is the most important thing in our relationship, would you say? Would that be psychological flexibility?

Therapist 09:51

It's a starting point. The starting point is the psychological flexibility of the of the individuals. But then it comes to I would say you could say communication skills. I would say engagement skills. It is the. for me. For me, the idea that there are actually three pillars in. Let's say, in a good relationship. Maybe I can. It starts with the psychological, the autonomy of the individual and the psychological flexibility. For me, those are means roughly to two parts. Then there is the the commitment and the emotional connection between partners. So this connection part. And the third one is the how much passion is there between partners and passion is not necessarily sexual, but is the willingness and the desire to create new energy, new experiences. And it is actually quite a bit of tension as well as the work of David Starch and Esther Patel. That is quite, quite a bit of tension between the stable connection parts and the more dynamic erotic passion parts. And for me that is where the autonomy, the autonomy, the psychological flexibility comes. And that's typically what David Charge and emphasizes uses the term differentiation, which we learned we took from Bowen. But differentiation is a bit of a technical term. But what I, what I mean with autonomy or psychological flexibility is more or less what they charge, which though when we meet with differentiation.

Interviewer 11:59

All right and that your your clients usually if that's usually what you've seen your clients as well this tension between the stability and the need for that.

Therapist 12:11

Yes. But I think that is true in monogamous relationships. But what one of the pitfalls in polyamorous and non monogamous relationship is if a couple is, let's say, ten, 20 years together and then there is a new partner, then of course, with a new partner, that passion is in terms of newness and excitement is much higher naturally than in, let's say, the existing stable partner. So we're working on passion in the existing first relationship as a partner is a prime importance to keep the first relationship stable. Yes, it's definitely an awfully big topic.

Interviewer 13:00

Interesting. So it's almost like a ladder that just needs to start with a psychological flexibility and autonomy and then commitment and connection and that passion. But for you, that's how you conceptualize your relationships often differ from how your clients conceptualize the relationship. And does this impact therapy?

Therapist 13:22

Can you repeat the question? I didn't fully.

Interviewer 13:25

Sure I was asking. You were telling me right this your your view on relationship quality and what makes a good relationship quality or high relationship quality. Does this then how you conceptualize relationships often differ from how your clients conceptualize relationships.

Therapist 13:49

I understand your question right now. Let's say if my view on a good quality of relationship is the same or different from what...

Interviewer 14:00

Exactly..

Therapist 14:07

I would say it depends. And so I mentioned that that let's say my typical...my typical couples it is one that wants to be more or faster, more non-monogamous and the other ones are less. That's typically the view that I have, is an attempt to be somewhere in the middle where we are a part of that. Want less or no, no or no more monogamy wants to be monogamous and is usually doesn't put that much emphasis on autonomy. And your couples were one of the just wants to go out and as many foreigners as they. Where, where, did better believe the focus is more ambitious? And so for me, actually, that's that's focus on differentiation, autonomy, psychological flexibility, whatever you call. It in actually the let's say, the glue between the two extremes.

That be the psychological flexibility gives both partners actually choice. They are not not not fused or associated with with with one of the extremes, either a new partner or connection that needed a psychological flexibility give you actually also the flexibility of choice. And that part is is not. That's part of what I usually add to the view of couples, and they usually see only one of them. And this is what I add. And when I ...most couple when they just don't think about it, when I when I hold it in front of them and they start recognizing some easier than others. There's been a lengthy answer for the visits.

Interviewer 16:33

There's definitely. Definitely. That's great. That's great. I wanted to ask as well. The relationship is a complex system that involves love, sex, identity, responsiveness, satisfaction, and all of that and more. During therapy, how do you decide which one to focus on? How do you decide which one in this complex system to target?

Therapist 16:54

Yeah, that's a very good question. That's a very good question. My standard approach is that each I start each session with the question, what is most important today? And so I actually I try to make essentially a contract per session. And from. So I like to work with with what what is currently at hand what what happens this week. And from that point, I start working on one of those topics that is usually apart. I have a strong methodology from from, let's say, assessment and to to approach. No, I don't. I don't.

Interviewer 17:49

So when do you determine when to end couples therapy?

Therapist 18:00

To be honest, there is there is a substantial part, let's say 25%, that they decide that non-monogamy is not going to work for them.

And so they either start giving up their attempts or towards the end of their relationship. So a couple decides this is not going to work for me. And then then the therapy was a last attempt to to get it working.

But I don't think this takes. But let's say 25%. And I have usually a bit of a flexible ending of the therapy, and so I don't have very long therapy trajectories. Usually five or six sessions and then they are. Then my aim is to, to, to get them get them on the, let's say, on speed and to take first first steps. And then when they are taking first steps, then I cut them loose. So as usual, but with the with the agreement to to to be in contact either in a month or two months or three months or so when they are taking first steps and they in opening their relationship and they are both comfortable that they're not getting and that's usually after five or six.

Interviewer 19:27

And how often are your therapy sessions with them? Is it every week? Every other week?

Therapist 19:35

Usually every fortnight.

Interviewer 19:38

All right. And how long are these sessions usually?

Therapist 19:43

With a couple one and half hours. individuals, one hour and a triangle or a quarter 2 hours.

Interviewer 19:53

All right. For one hour for singles and then two for. All right. And for for these triangles and quads, these tend to be the ones who are already right. They wouldn't see your advice on opening the relationship. So can you ask what usually is like when they come to you? What are they seeking your service for these triangles and quads?

Therapist 20:24

There are not many of them. So it is usually a couples or individuals. So I don't have statistics. I actually do two type of triangles. One is that it is an existing couple and there is a new partner coming in. And actually there's usually there's always an existing couple and then a new person enters and then they And sometimes they they have one of them is not not not fully engaged yet in the triangle or if they are engaged, other than then communication gets just difficult. Usually communication.

And that is where I read, where I put transactional analysis in. I usually typically either use either EFT or transactional communication. EFT is more for the, let's say, the conflict de-escalation part and transactional analysis is more, let's say next level communication with. Okay, but still you get conflicts and how do you deal with it.

Interviewer 21:48

And usually these communication, the topic of their conflicts would center around what is it like a sort of they don't feel part of the couple is about sex is.... ?

Therapist 22:01

It's always about, let's say the umbrella term jealousy. And then jealousy is actually an umbrella term for difficult emotions. And it can be I feel excluded. I don't feel good enough. My self esteem is is part I'm afraid that you leave the most important parts for the whole way of sometimes existential fears that can happen. And roughly it's 50% about sex and 50% about an emotional connection. That's the more interesting part. And if someone has a different you quite often one partner is comfortable with either the partner having sex with someone else or have an emotional connection with someone else. But the combination is difficult but are roughly and roughly 50% has a difficulty with an emotional connection. So falling in love as well. Sex is fine. For instance, swingers I see quite a bit of swingers that are comfortable that the partner having sex with others. But then someone falls in love and that's difficult. But there's also the other way around, and people can hardly imagine that it

can be the other way around. So it's an interesting part. So it's very much into their own truth there.

Interviewer 23:44

And is this similar for quads as well? Is that ...

Therapist 23:51

Actually, there are very, very, very little quotes that that actually are very, very little stable quads. And usually quads are formed by two couples meeting some sometimes two three couples. And usually difficulty with with the quads is that that there are at least four relationships. You could say there are even even more. But let's keep it simple. Four. And there's always the weakest link. And and that weakest, weakest link breaks up. So quads and triangles especially quads, triangles have quite a different dynamic.

Interviewer 24:42

And the weakest link the source of the breakup. Would this be the same thing? Jealousy feeling?

Therapist 24:49

Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. Jealousy is in a very broad sense, but. But the more I look at the concept of jealousy, I think by now I distinguish something like ten different kinds of jealousy.

Interviewer 25:07

Interesting. Would you write this up anywhere in the future? Sure. Would you write this up anywhere in the future?

Therapist 25:18

Yeah. I plan to do so. I plan to.

Interviewer 25:21

I'd love to. I'd love to get the heads up. If you ever get this out to the world in the future. As you know as well from the email, we are currently developing a relationship quality scale that hopefully better represents the relationship as a complex system that aims to help therapists both in treatment planning and in treatment evaluations. How interested would you be in a scale like this?

Therapist 25:47

Yes, I would be interested. But. But I recognized that the dynamics of of non-monogamy is. Is, is. It's different. At least different, I think also more difficult, but at least different. But I doubt whether actually that one scale will have. Its it should be more a multi dimensional, multi dimensional assessment are either plot or one scale giving relationship quality. To me, that's not going to work.

Interviewer 26:40

We're actually thinking of it as more of a battery. More of an inventory of. multiple subscales for for us to develop while we developing this. We want to know, like, how would

this be if in a scale like this, what would you be looking for personally or professionally? And how can we make sure that this scale is useful for you?

Therapist 27:07

Now for me, it should compose those three sub domains, so the autonomy, individual psychological flexibility part. It should contain a part of the quality of connection. And there is there is at least two subparts in that there is commitment and there is emotional. What makes you. So that's the love triangle of of those names. CHAPMAN Yeah, yes. Passion, commitment and emotional connection. I in my in my model, I combine commitment and emotional connection. I keep out and I think those those three. And passion. But passion is more than sex only. Wherever there is also an emotional passion. Joint equal to joint self development or is also a spiritual dimension.

Interviewer 28:33

All right.

Therapist 28:38

So? So. Those three subdomains but and I guess that that fourth autonomy. Well, I'd say the model of ACT could work. Let's say six domains are at least that good for me. Could be a good starting point. So something like that. And. I'm saying this from a non-monogamous perspective, but but I'm arrogant enough to think that this is true for any relationship where the autonomy part is usually got

Interviewer 29:20

Interesting. All right. So we are planning to carefully develop this and validate the scale over the course of two or three years. More after this. Afterwards, we will be selling it just to recoup development costs for the scale. We wanted to get a sense of how much budget there is actually for practitioners in buying these scales. Like if you were to buy a new scale like this, what would be the set?

Therapist 29:49

As I said, I don't pay for scales and I don't I. I have no clue. I have no clue. To be honest, it's. And for me I do this work also quite a bit from ideological perspective. I will be aware that that's that relationship therapists are not the highest paid therapists. I don't know not a huge capital.

Interviewer 30:34

All right. But we are. But the good news is that we are planning to make it for free. We are planning to to make it free eventually. We just need to reach a certain amount, like the cost development goals.

[Portion Redacted]

Interviewer 31:19

Definitely. All right. Of course, you've already. You're already helping in the development of the skill just by this interview. But would you be interested in collaborating more for the development of the skill?

Therapist 31:31

Depends. What do you would practice, what you would ask for me... if you ask in general? Yes. In general I open to contribute.

Interviewer 31:47

Once the scale is finished, we will send it to you for feedback. Let us know your thoughts, etc. etc.. Once we have then the modified sort of tentative final version of the scale, we will be giving it to a couple of therapists for free, for example, for six months and then after the end of six months it would be asking your experience about it. But you're like you didn't like if it had clinical utility for you, etc., would that be something you would be interested in?

Therapist 32:20

Yeah, well, I would be interested to look at it if it were very for sure.

Interviewer 32:28

All right, great. So one of these.

Therapist 32:32

And and then, of course, I expect a let's say a very decent discount on.

Interviewer 32:38

Definitely. But yes, one of these months, I'll just email you out of the blue. All right. We are actually just wrapping up, so I will be reviewing just very quickly what we have talked about in the session and maybe if you want to, if we missed something, if you want to add more, please just cut me off in the middle as well. [Portion Redacted] So when clients come to you, usually for couples one wants to be non, one wants to open their relationship, one wants to stay monogamous or otherwise it's about engage in conflicts or difficulties. And then of course, you also talked about the triangles and the ones with a different dynamic. You would later on talk about the dynamic of the triangles as having an existing couple and then the plus one. Maybe one isn't fully engaged or one is feeling jealousy or feeling excluded or afraid that the other is going to leave. But the dynamic for the quad is often different to me. Typically two couples meeting, for example, two swingers. And you said that is always a conflict, which again involves the jealousy. They usually cause their quad to to break up. You don't do a formal assessment. You do have an intake session, you don't you did have an AFD related questionnaire. You then have an ACT related questionnaire, but you find it very limited. Do you still give these out actually these days?

Therapist 34:42

No.

Interviewer 34:43

Did you just do it on your [1-5] year as couples therapy, couples therapists?

Therapist 34:50

No, I did it, incidentally. But not. Not, not.

Interviewer 35:00

All right. So I also ask about relationship quality and for you, a good relationship...

Therapist 35:06

There is one element to to to also to look at from a practical practitioner like myself, is that that the let's say once once you have a bit of experience an intake question, you sense quite, quite a bit in a sense. Quite a bit. So in typically in a quarter of an hour, I understand quite a bit of the dynamics of, a couple. And so is this let's say in a in a non structured I have a few questions I an intake questions are read it and within 50 minutes and you know actually quite quite a bit. So in terms of an assessment tool it's I could really use it as a preparation. I would then it should not, it should not, it should be. That's what I meant with great tooling it should actually cost me no time. So I send out a link and I gather I get a report and with, with, with some nice graphs and. Let's go.

Interviewer 36:28

Definitely.

Therapist 36:29

So time efficiency of, of an assessment is is extremely important.

Interviewer 36:37

Perfect. All right.

Therapist 36:43

Hey, if it's going to cost and I think that will be true for for any practitioner. So if it takes a quarter of an hour, it's too much.

Interviewer 36:49

For sure. All right. And when we talked about relationship quality, you really said that good relationship is a combination of a stable but resilient relationship between autonomous individuals. And for you, what differentiates couples with high relationship quality and those lower relationship quality? You talked about those three important components, which is almost like a ladder. As we were saying, the starting point would be psychological flexibility and economies and then connection, which involves both the emotional connection and the commitments as well as passion, which, as you said, isn't only about sex, but also about the emotional passion or the curiosity for the other individual, etc., Did you mention as well about spirituality in this passion. Did I catch that correctly? Yeah. In what kind of sense? What would the spirituality come in?

Therapist 37:50

How can I explain? Is that we can have all discussion what spiritual means. But what I mean

in this context is not not so much a transcendent type of spirituality, but more in terms of of meaning joins a joint meaning. And that could could extend, let's say, a transcend you mentioned transcend type of spirituality. But but but I would connect it very much to.to meaning. And a general an ideology. So ideology a common purpose maybe those words. I won't say common purpose.

Interviewer 38:54

That's very interesting. All right. And then we also thought about how you conceptualize your relationships and how your clients conceptualize their relationship. And for you, your clarity was Therapy really adds to the view of the couples about the psychological flexibility, about the differentiation. It gives both partners a choice and not just not just a fixation and not just a rigidity. And we also talked about how you target which of the complex system of the relationship to focus on during the session. And for you, it's like what's important for the day? What's important?

Therapist 39:37

It's very much question driven. So what what I oh, it starts already in the beginning, but it's very much case driven and that's and it is not. It is also a choice. And so so active is also as a component of mindfulness in it. And so so case driven gives the opportunity to be very much in the here and now. And so what is now important?

Interviewer 40:09

All right. And then also talked about the sort of determine when to enter therapy. And you said that for 25% of the clients that you have, it's not for them or non-monogamy wouldn't be for them. So they start seeing you. But otherwise, for couples, it's 5 to 6 sessions before their first steps in opening the relationship.

Therapist 40:38

If they are comfortable, they're comfortable. To set the first steps and then off together.

Interviewer 40:40

Is this a similar timeline as well for the triangles and quads of how long?

Therapist 40:46

Because I wouldn't know that I can't do statistics.. Yeah. For the triangles as well.

Interviewer 40:57

Perfect. All right, so every two weeks, 1.5 hours for the couples, one or two for for triangles and quads. And we also talked about, of course, the development of the scale. And for you, what will help scale will is that it should be dimensional. It should encompass the three things that we talked about psychological flexibility, passion, connection. And it should also be time efficient. So it should also automatically report graphs, etc.. Let's give you the results

immediately and you'll go through would be interested in the development scale. Is there anything you would want to add to that?

Therapist 41:40

No, I don't think at this point.

Interviewer 41:43

All right. So before we end, I'd like to talk to you about how we will handle the data as well. Of course, as a research project, we want it to be as open and as transparent as ethically possible, as verifiable for the future readers. So I wanted to know which data sharing option you're more comfortable with. One option is that Transcript portions of this interview can be shared, none of which can be identified back to you. Another option is that the whole if you were bolder is that the whole transcript can be shared, removed of sensitive and overly identifying details. So it will still be anonymized and there will be more context to what we're talking about. However, there is a risk here that people might know your professional you well can piece together the details in the transcript and might narrow it down to who among their colleagues is although again, no sensitive information for sharing of these two options. Which one are you more comfortable with?

Therapist 42:52

What? I thought there were three, but there are two. What are the two? Can you summarize?

Interviewer 42:58

Sure. The first one was only transcript portion will only be the one shared and it will be decontextualized. The other option is the whole transcript can be shared, removed certain sensitive details and identifying details.

Therapist 43:13

I would be comfortable with the first.

Interviewer 43:15

No problem at all. All right. And I think that would be it, actually. But I'm sorry. Maybe I just like to take this opportunity as well. You have a very unique perspective. Not many would specialize in non-monogamy and open relationships. And I want to actually explore more of this, especially with those specializing LGBTQ as well, etc.. Would you have other potential contacts that might be interested in this project as well?

Therapist 43:52

Yeah. perhaps. I'm not sure if she's interested, but it could be my colleague. [Name] She works here either. Actually, she. We don't work in the same practice, but we cooperate quite a lot. As a slightly different. She. She works also in this field, but she has a slightly different field line. That's not very much, but slightly.

Interviewer 44:28

You are right. I'll just.

Therapist 44:31

I emphasize more the autonomy part.

Interviewer 44:34

Interesting. All right. So I'll email you for that shortly after this. Yeah. Thank you so much. It has been great knowing you. And that does a great session. Have a great rest of the day. Thank you so much. All right. Bye bye.